Xinghao Yao

School of Economics, The University of Queensland | Brisbane, Australia
xinghao.yao@uq.edu.au

Research Fields

Primary: Behavioural Economics; AI-related.
Secondary: Experimental Economics; Information Economics; Auctions and Market Design.

References

Lionel Page
Professor of Economics
School of Economics
The University of Queensland
lionel.page@uq.edu.au

Kenan Kalayci
Senior Lecturer
School of Economics
The University of Queensland
k.kalayci@uq.edu.au

Zachary Breig
Senior Lecturer
School of Economics
The University of Queensland
z.breig@uq.edu.au

Job Market Paper

How Robust Is LLM Economic Decision-Making? An Auction Benchmark
with Kenan Kalayci

Economic robustness requires both appropriate adjustment to changing fundamentals and resistance to information that theory predicts should not affect decisions. Using a benchmark of 78 auction environments, we evaluate six large language models (LLMs) in nine configurations against equilibrium predictions for risk-neutral bidders. We find that strong performance is often specific to particular conditions and decisions. In first-price auctions, high bidding accuracy under uniformly distributed private values does not consistently carry over to normally distributed private values. These limits also emerge across connected decisions: entry or information-purchase frequencies close to theoretical predictions can coexist with inaccurate subsequent bids. Conversely, accurate bids among entrants can coexist with entry frequencies far from those predictions. In first-price auctions with costly entry, historical-price information is associated with bidding changes and generally higher entry-error rates than without this information, despite leaving theoretical predictions unchanged. Without an entry decision, most configurations' bids change little across historical-price conditions. These findings support evaluating LLMs under the economic conditions and across the connected decisions relevant to their intended use, since isolated successes and aggregate scores can conceal substantial gaps in performance.

Working Papers

Information Disclosure in Private-Value Auctions
with Kenan Kalayci | *Working paper*

What You See Is All There Is? A Registered Direct Replication of Enke (2020)
R&R | Journal of the Economic Science Association

This paper reports a registered direct replication of Enke (2020) in a different language, laboratory and software implementation. Participants estimate the mean of a full set of signals after observing a selected subset. Those who must infer the implications of hidden signals place excessive weight on the mean of visible signals compared with participants given an explicit summary of the hidden information. The replication supports the main finding, but provides only limited support for the proposed mechanism that unobserved information is neglected because it fails to come to mind. Greater computational complexity increases such neglect.

Sponsorship Disclosure as a Strategic Informational Cue: A Two-Sided Labelling Model and Meta-Analysis of Influencer Marketing
with Tianyuan Feng | *Major revision* | *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science (FT50)*

This paper integrates a two-sided labelling model with a three-level meta-analysis of 63 articles, 89 studies and 258 effect sizes. It studies how sponsorship disclosure affects consumer responses and how these effects vary across products, influencers and audiences. The evidence points to persuasion knowledge as a central mechanism behind the negative average effect of disclosure on consumer responses, relative to no disclosure. My contribution was to develop the paper's two-sided labelling model.

From Analysis to Affect: Modeling and Measuring Finfluencer Communication with Generative LLMs
with Tianyuan Feng | *Under review* | *Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science (FT50)*

The same investment view can be presented through analytical reasoning or emotional expression. We examine how the former shapes finfluencers' perceived competence and why analysis matters when emotion draws more engagement. Using a codebook-guided large language model, we classify 47,707 posts from 396 finfluencers on X. Emotional expression is associated with more likes and replies than analytical content, with a stronger advantage for emotion-dominant posts by widely followed creators. Our model explains why analysis can remain valuable despite this disadvantage: the reputation it builds supports engagement with both formats. Two preregistered experiments reproduce emotion's advantage in liking intentions, strengthened by a higher displayed follower count, while showing that analysis increases perceived competence. Mediation analyses link this competence benefit to following and subscription intentions. Together, the model and evidence suggest that analysis can contribute to an engagement-oriented strategy by signaling competence and supporting interest in future content.

My contribution comprises the economic modelling and generative LLM-based textual analysis, including the classification of semantic content and discrete emotion frames.

Work in Progress

Accuracy or Affirmation? Competition in AI Advice Markets

Underquoting in Endogenous Entry Auctions

Do you know how attractive you are? A Two-Sided Search Model with Self-Uncertainty

Education

The University of Queensland **2023-present**
PhD in Economics (expected early 2027)
Supervisors: Kenan Kalayci and Lionel Page.

The University of Queensland **2022**
Master of Advanced Economics

The University of Queensland **2018-2021**
Master of Applied Econometrics

Huaqiao University **2013-2017**
BEng in Industrial Design

Research Collaboration

Project Silicon
Contribute experimental data and replication materials, and review simulation results based on our experiments.

Teaching Experience	**Tutor, The University of Queensland** Microeconomic Analysis: student evaluation 4.93/5. Introduction to Econometrics: student evaluation 4.8/5.	**2023-2026**
Conferences	Asia-Pacific ESA Meeting, University of Melbourne | Presenter	2026
	Australasian Economic Theory Workshop (AETW), Auckland | Presenter	2026
	Australian PhD Conference in Economics and Business, UNSW | Presenter	2025
	Summer School in Experimental and Behavioral Economics, University of Crete | Participant	2025
	Foundations of Utility and Risk (FUR), The University of Queensland | Presenter	2024
Other Related Experience	Research Assistant, UQ QSMAT program.	
	Summer Research Scholar, The University of Queensland	2019-2020
	Master's thesis: constructed a Chinese financial-text corpus incorporating domain-specific expressions for sentiment classification and predicting the direction of stock price movements.	
	DiDi, Safety Department: behavioural analysis	Jun-Nov 2017
Research Skills and Languages	Methods: laboratory experiments, applied econometrics, game-theoretic modelling, machine learning and natural language processing.	
	Software: Python (proficient); Stata, R and MATLAB (working knowledge); oTree.	
	Languages: Mandarin (native); English (fluent).	